

APOLIPOPROTEIN E ISOFORMS, SERUM CHOLESTEROL, AND CANCER

SIR,—It is unclear whether the relation between low serum cholesterol levels and cancer¹ is causal. In many studies 'occult' tumour may have depressed cholesterol levels though in others the relation was found when serum cholesterol had been measured many years before the cancer was diagnosed. The relation is probably not explained by diet, because in the Seven Countries Study cohorts with widely different diets and corresponding differences in mean cholesterol levels experienced similar mean cancer rates.^{2,3} On the other hand, within each region cancer incidence was higher in men with a serum cholesterol in the lowest part of the cholesterol distribution for that country.³ Thus, naturally low cholesterol levels are sometimes associated with increased cancer risk.^{1,3}

Differences in the aminoacid sequence of apolipoprotein E (apo

Katan, Lancet, (1986)